

QUALITY OF QUALITY TESTING MATTERS

Today's quality-sensitive competitive markets have opened up new avenues for engineers in the field of quality and testing. Read on to know the prerequisites and scope of building a career in this fast-evolving domain

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In the year 1991, Dr Manmohan Singh, the then finance minister of India, introduced economic reforms that ushered in the era of liberalisation, privatisation and globalisation. A whole new set of policies on international trade and investment, tax reforms and deregulation were introduced.

As the Indian industries opened up to scrutinising foreign investors, the quality of products manufactured across all sectors became very crucial to the Indian companies. It soon became clear that in order to survive in an open market and meet the customers' expectations, they had to manufacture quality products. That is when the relevance and importance of quality testing departments first emerged.

Quality testing in electronics has since then become a common practice. From personal computers to home appliances, car components and industrial electronics, quality testing is part of every manufacturing business. Before any product is sold, it is required to undergo testing and quality control. It is the quality testing professionals who carry out these tests and approve of a product's compliance to set quality standards.

According to Anil Bali, vice president, Deki Electronics, "The role of quality testing professionals is to assure product quality by strictly adher-



ing to the standardised organisational norm. They must ensure that the desired product quality is maintained during the product's processing stage as well as at the time of its final release. They are also responsible for carry-

ing out the Six Sigma activity in the company."

Six Sigma activities in a company combine the use of quality management techniques with statistical data to identify the causes of defects in a product and remove the defects.

Quality testing professionals are required to constantly analyse the data available to them, and compile test results to make recommendations to product developers and quality assurance professionals in order to better the products.

"Quality testing professionals do online inspection of processes and monitor incoming material. They are also responsible for inspection of the outgoing products from the factory.

The key focus is to prevent defective products from going to customers, and control and prevent defects in the process," says N.P. Manjunath, senior general manager, Hical Technologies.

Where to begin

Quality management and testing techniques are offered as optional modules in all graduate-level engineering courses. Lately, a few

Based on their products and processes, companies have specific requirements for quality testing professionals and hire accordingly— N.P. Manjunath, senior general manager, Hical Technologies